CAROLINE KELLY

MUSIC AND BRAND PARTNERSHIPS

For independent labels and managers

Find the brand that fits your act, then measure what it changed.

THE PROBLEM Labels and managers tend to pitch the brands they already know. After the campaign, it is hard to say what it changed, because nobody recorded the numbers beforehand.

Data analyst · MSc Business Analytics, UCL

Portfolio ↗ CV ↗ LinkedIn ↗

WHERE I FIT

Big brands and major labels already have this. Independents mostly don't.

Matching artists to brands on audience data, then measuring the result, is common at the top of the market. It is rarely within reach of an independent label, or a manager with a mid-sized act.

01

The top of the market

Brand and artist matching platforms such as Music Audience Exchange, sponsorship data from SponsorUnited, and agencies' own in-house tools. Built for big brands and big budgets.

02

Major labels

Their own brand partnership teams and data, much as sport has had for years. My Williams model is that kind of tool.

03

Independents

Independent labels, and managers of mid-sized acts. Usually no data team, and the best fit is often a smaller brand rather than the biggest name. This is who I work with.

THE PROBLEM Independent labels and managers rarely have the data or the team that the top of the market has.

WHAT I DO I bring the same matching and measurement to one release or activation, and look for brands the right size for the act.

Music Audience Exchange and SponsorUnited are named as examples of what exists at the top end · Major-label teams are my reading of the market

01

PREDICTION

Who to approach, and when.

I rank the brands most likely to say yes to an artist, and say why now. I built this for Formula One sponsorship at Williams.

04 Proof: Williams F1

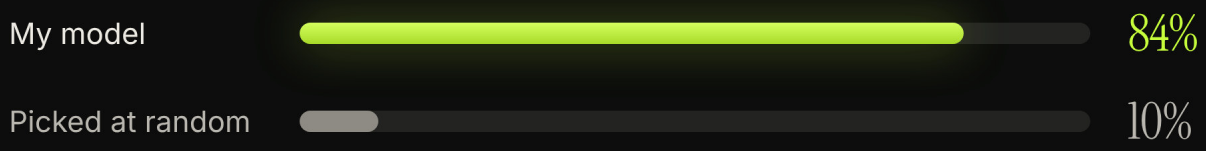
05 The method, pointed at music

06 Which acts to back: Beggars Group

01 · PROOF: WILLIAMS F1

At Williams, I built the tool the partnerships team uses to decide who to call.

5 in 6 companies that went on to sponsor were already in the top 10% of my scores (84%). Tested on companies the model hadn't seen.



340,000+

past sponsorship deals across all sports, over several years, from the data in Williams' CRM. The model learned from these.

13,296

companies scored every week, inside Salesforce

WHY IT CARRIES OVER TO MUSIC

The inputs were company financials, past deal history and news timing. None of them is specific to sport.

THE PROBLEM — Partnership teams spend their time on the brands they already know.

WHAT I DO — I rank every prospect on whether it can spend, why now, and how it compares with past sponsors.

Summer placement that became my UCL dissertation (May to Sep 2026), with Atlassian Williams Racing's commercial team · Results only, no company information · Python, Salesforce, BigQuery

01 · THE METHOD, POINTED AT MUSIC

For each act, I rank the brands most likely to say yes, and why now.

I'm adapting my Williams model for music. Until that version is built, I put the first shortlist together by hand from the same signals.

01

Can they spend?

The right size

Revenue and headcount, so the list holds brands that can afford a real deal and suit the act's size, not only the biggest names.

A track record

Have they backed music, culture or sport before? Past sponsors were the strongest guide at Williams.

\+

02

Why now?

News timing

A product launch, a new market, a rebrand or new funding. At Williams, news like this was part of every score.

The calendar

Matched to the act's release, tour and festival dates.

\+

03

Do they fit the act?

Same fans

The brand's target age and cities against the artist's audience, from streaming and YouTube data.

Right for the artist

The artist and their manager have the final say on every brand.

= WHAT A SHORTLIST LOOKS LIKE A made-up example: a London electronic act, album out in March, with listeners growing in Paris and Berlin.

1 A trainer brand opening a Paris store

Its customers match the act's age range, and the opening is close to the release.

2 A headphone brand that sponsors club nights

It has backed music before, and the act tours clubs in both cities.

3 A drinks brand entering Germany

New-market news makes this the moment to approach it, ahead of the Berlin show.

THE PROBLEM Managers and labels pitch familiar brands, often without a clear reason why now.

WHAT I DO I give each act a short ranked list of brands, with the reason each fits and when to approach them.

Signals are those my Williams model used (financials, past deals, news timing), plus audience fit for music · The example act and brands are made up to show the format

Which acts should a brand back? I tested a way to tell on Beggars Group's roster.

The last slide picks brands for an act. This is the other half of the match: which acts keep the fans a brand reaches. Beggars is the test case, and the same check works on any label.

53 acts across XL, 4AD, Matador, Rough Trade and Young against 20 major and indie comparators, from public data.

Loyalty

Fans kept, against what the act's size predicts. A brand wants fans who are still there after the campaign.

Growth

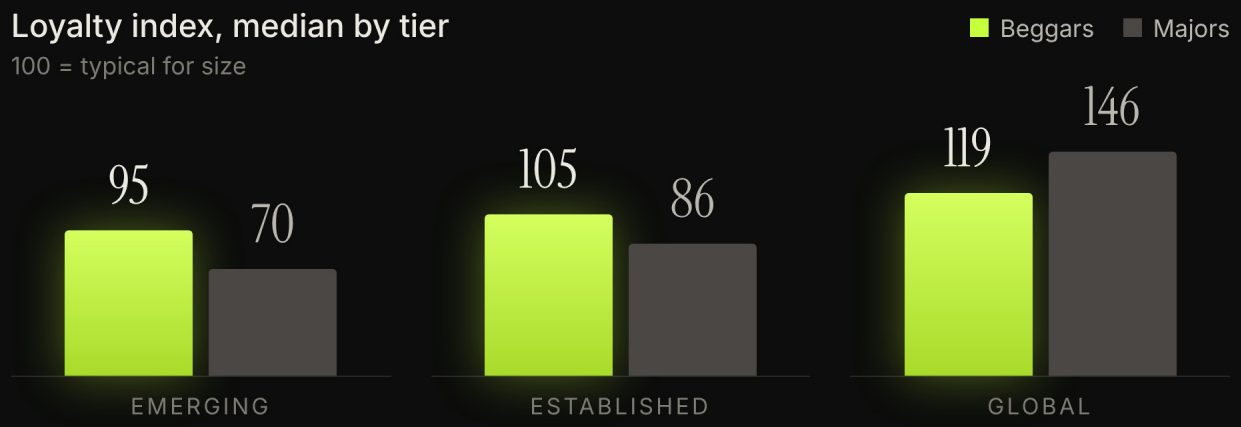
Follower change over 30 days. It shows which acts are reaching new people.

Reach

Top countries for the act's YouTube views. It shows which markets a brand gets.

Loyalty index, median by tier

100 = typical for size



0.60% Beggars growth

1.00% Majors growth

WHAT I FOUND

Beggars acts hold their fans better at emerging and established level, but grew more slowly. At global level the majors lead.

THE PROBLEM

Labels have many acts, and it isn't clear which ones suit a brand partnership.

WHAT I DO

I score a roster on loyalty and growth, then rerun the loyalty score three months after a campaign to see whether new fans stayed.

Chartmetric snapshot, 15 Oct 2026, and Spotify Web API · Repo lets-play-analytics, notebook 03 · One 30-day window · Full analysis and method: A1 and A2

02

MEASUREMENT

Proving what it did.

I capture the before, then track the campaign against comparison acts, so you can show what it changed.

08 The measurement gap

09 Worked example: RIP Magic

10 How a project runs

02 · THE MEASUREMENT GAP

You can’t show what changed if nobody wrote down the before.

If measuring starts after the moment, there is no baseline, and a rise could have many causes.

THE MOMENT

01 · BEFORE

Capture the before

The artist and three or four comparison acts: listeners, followers, saves, search and top cities. Everything after depends on it.

02 · + 2 WEEKS

Did it reach new people?

The first result. The change is measured against the comparison acts, so a playlist add or a viral clip isn’t credited to the brand.

03 · + 3 MONTHS

Did the new fans stay?

The loyalty measure from my Beggars work shows whether the new fans stuck around.

WHAT I CAN’T MEASURE ALONE

Brand lift and sales need the brand’s own data or a survey. Dr. Martens tracked brand confidence and awareness for its gigs and called sales “a by-product” (Amplify, 2020).

THE PROBLEM

After a campaign, it is often impossible to say what it changed, because the numbers before it were never recorded.

WHAT I DO

I record the before, then compare the act with similar acts at two weeks and at three months.

Amplify, Dr. Martens case study, 2020 · My review of measurement sources (IPA, Kantar, YouGov, WARC), Oct 2026

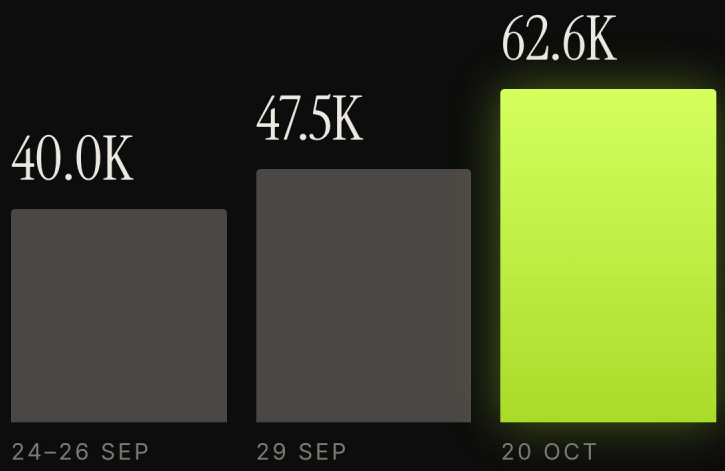


Their debut album played through modded car systems in south-east London before its 30 October release (2026). No brand was involved.

02 · WORKED EXAMPLE: RIP MAGIC

RIP Magic's listeners jumped 56% around their car meet. The data points to a playlist add.

SPOTIFY MONTHLY LISTENERS, 2026



THE CHECK

Over the same weeks, playlist reach rose 63% and followers stayed flat, with no jump after the car meet. That points to a playlist add, not the playback.

WHY IT IS HERE

No brand paid for this. It shows the check I would run on a paid campaign before crediting the brand.

THE PROBLEM

A rise in listeners can easily be credited to the wrong thing.

WHAT I DO

I check every rise against playlist reach, followers and comparison acts before saying what caused it.

Chartmetric, 24 Sep to 20 Oct 2026 · Stereogum 2026 · Car meet date not confirmed, so the window is approximate

02 · HOW A PROJECT RUNS

How it would run on your next release or activation.

~1 month from the first call to the first read-back

5–7 days of my time

WEEK 0

One call

We agree the act, the moment, and what success looks like.

WEEK 1

Shortlist and before

A first brand shortlist, built by hand from the Williams signals, and the before snapshot.

THE MOMENT

It happens

A release, a show or a drop. I log anything else going on, like playlist adds or press.

+ 2 WEEKS

First result

A two-page read-back: what changed against the comparison acts.

+ 3 MONTHS

Did fans stay?

Whether the new fans stayed, where they are, and whether to back the act again.

FOR A NEWER ACT

Is the fan base growing, and in which cities?

FOR AN ACT WITH A NEW ALBUM

Can a partner put it in front of people who don’t know the act yet?

FOR A LONG-STANDING ACT

Did the moment reach younger fans beyond the loyal core?

THE PROBLEM — Managers need to know what a project involves before they agree to one.

WHAT I DO — I keep it to one release or activation, with a fixed scope, a first result at two weeks and a final read at three months.

Timings are my estimate, from how my existing pipeline runs: Spotify Web API and public counts on fixed dates · Search and social need a small addition

THE ASK

Let me help on your next campaign.

The first project is one release or activation, for an independent label or a manager with a mid-sized act. I bring a shortlist of brands to approach, record the before, and send back a two-page read within two weeks of the moment.

Brands to approach

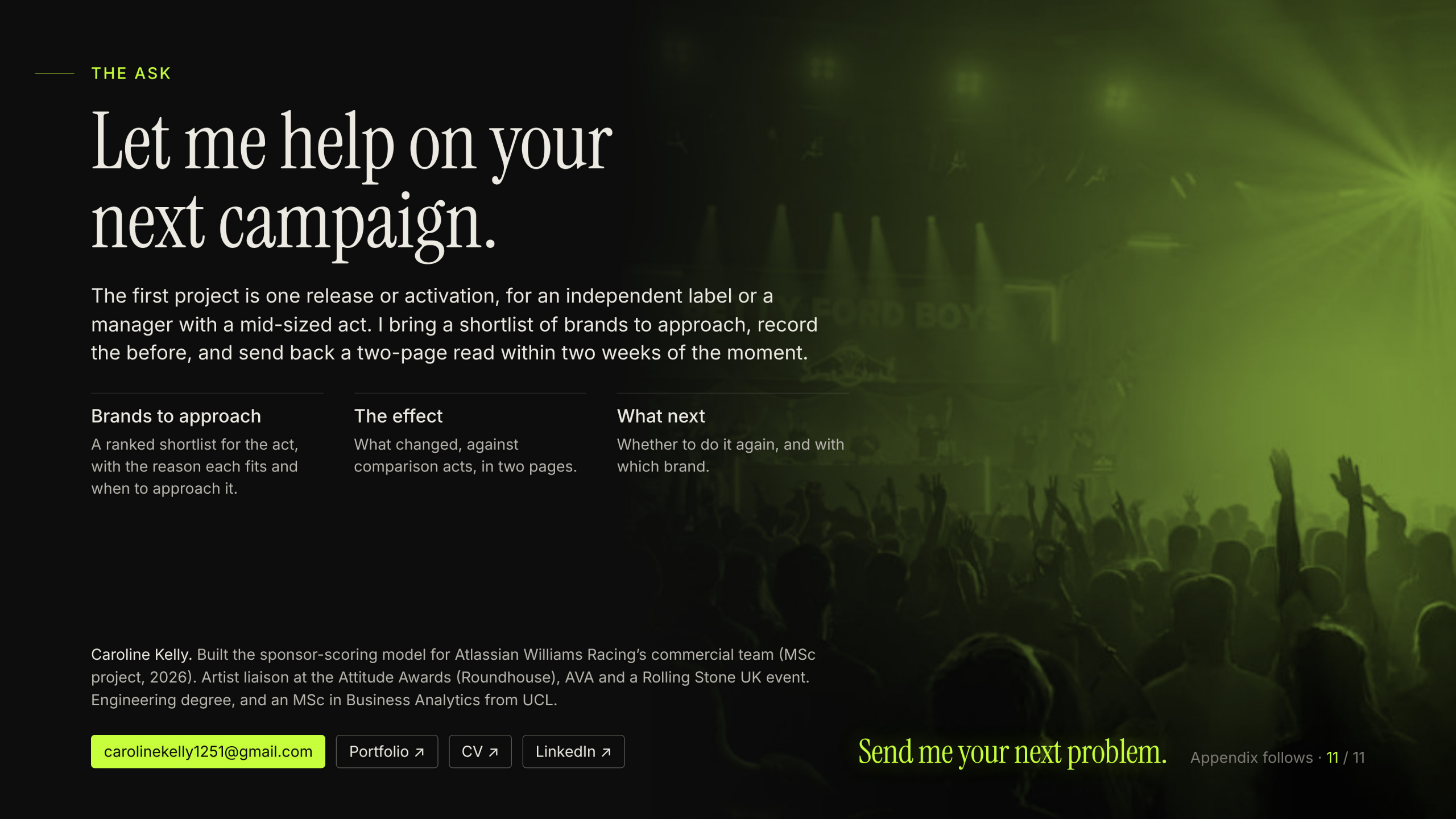
A ranked shortlist for the act, with the reason each fits and when to approach it.

The effect

What changed, against comparison acts, in two pages.

What next

Whether to do it again, and with which brand.



Caroline Kelly. Built the sponsor-scoring model for Atlassian Williams Racing's commercial team (MSc project, 2026). Artist liaison at the Attitude Awards (Roundhouse), AVA and a Rolling Stone UK event. Engineering degree, and an MSc in Business Analytics from UCL.

carolinekelly1251@gmail.com · Portfolio ↗ · CV ↗ · LinkedIn ↗

Send me your next problem.

A

Appendix

The analysis, method and market evidence behind the main pages.

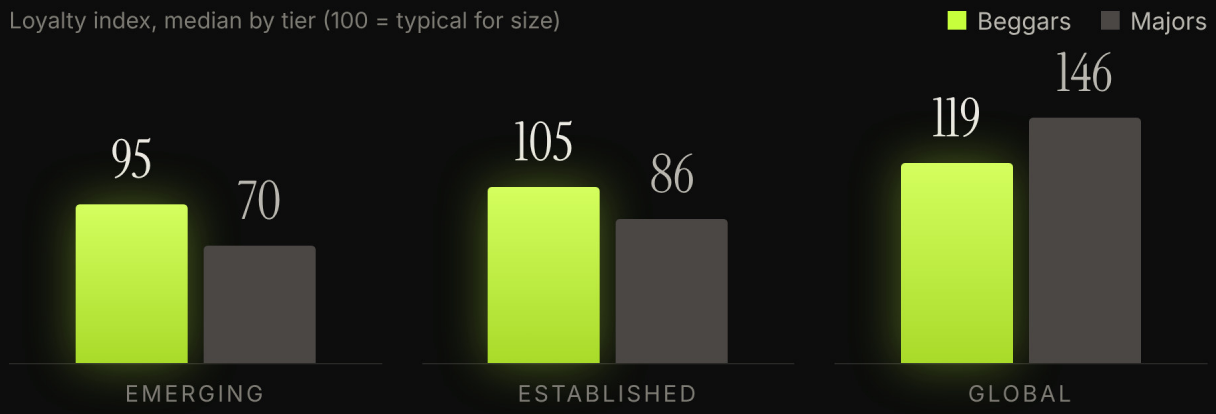
A1	The analysis	Beggars Group
A2	The method	Raw data to tested code
A3	Why now	The market
A4	The squeeze	Artist income
A5	Who’s doing it	Brands in the scene

Beggars acts hold their fans better, but aren't growing faster.

A loyal fan base gives a brand an audience that is still there after the campaign.

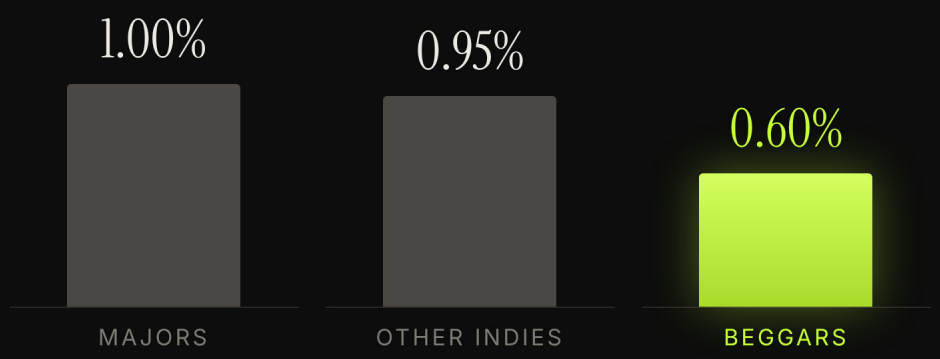
Beggars acts keep more of their fans than majors at emerging and established level

Loyalty index, median by tier (100 = typical for size)



Beggars acts grow about 40% slower than the majors

Median 30-day Spotify follower growth to 15 Oct 2026



WHAT I MEASURED

53 acts on Beggars labels (XL, 4AD, Matador, Rough Trade, Young) against majors and other indies, from APIs and public data.

WHAT I FOUND

Beggars acts lead on loyalty at emerging and established level but grow the slowest, and the two run against each other (r = −0.48).

WHAT IT MEANS

Streams outside the US grew 11.8% in early 2026 (Luminate), yet 95% of brands stay in one market (SponsorUnited).

WHAT A PROJECT WOULD TEST

Loyalty is measured here, but whether a brand partnership helps an act grow is not. A project would test it, with a before and after on a real campaign.

Method: A2 · Repo lets-play-analytics, notebooks 03 and 05 · Luminate Midyear 2026 · SponsorUnited 2023-24

APPENDIX A2 · THE METHOD

How I built it, from raw data to tested code.

STEP	WHAT I DID	TOOLS AND CHECKS
01 Roster	73 acts: 53 on Beggars labels, 20 comparators (majors, plus Domino and Dirty Hit as indie controls), across three size tiers. I checked the labels of 95 acts, as some ‘independents’ are major-distributed.	Hand-built CSV, source and date on every row, so any label’s roster can be swapped in.
02 Data and APIs	All from APIs and public data. Chartmetric snapshot, 15 Oct 2026: 73 artist pages saved and parsed in Python. Spotify Web API called for genres.	Raw files never edited. Spotify returned no genres, so I left breadth out of the score.
03 Loyalty index	Followers regressed on monthly listeners. The residual shows who keeps more fans than their size predicts (100 is typical).	src/ces.py, medians by tier. My first version measured casual reach, so I flipped it.
04 Growth	Spotify follower growth over the 30 days to 15 October 2026, medians by group.	One window only, so I call the gap small and say it may move.
05 Score and robustness	Mean of loyalty and growth. Pearson r = −0.48 between them. Ranking retested under 500 random weightings.	Fontaines D.C. and Olivia Dean were top ten in 97% of runs. Results depend on weighting.
06 Geography and events	Top-three YouTube countries per act, and listeners, followers and playlist reach before and after each live moment.	Chartmetric history. Geography is nine acts, so illustrative.

TOOLKIT Python and pandas in tested modules, Jupyter notebooks with jupytext twins, 11 pytest tests that pass before any notebook runs, and Git. Repo: lets-play-analytics.

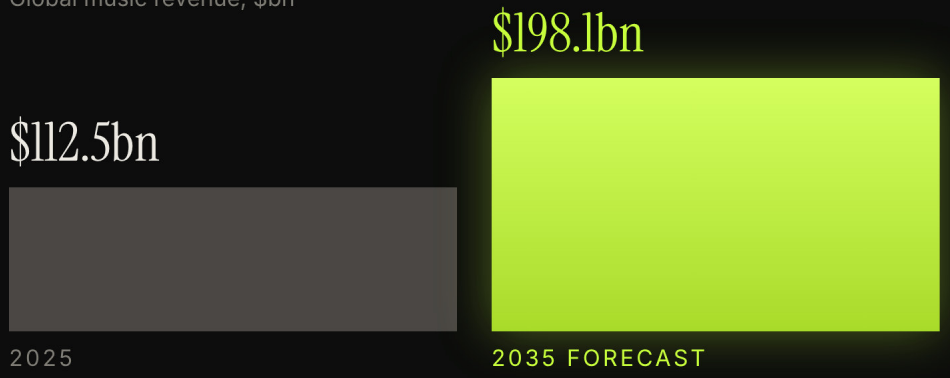
Chartmetric, 15 Oct 2026 · Spotify Web API · My label check, 21 Oct 2026

Music's money is growing. Sponsorship lags behind.

Music revenue is set to grow 76% in ten years, yet sport still takes seven times the sponsorship.

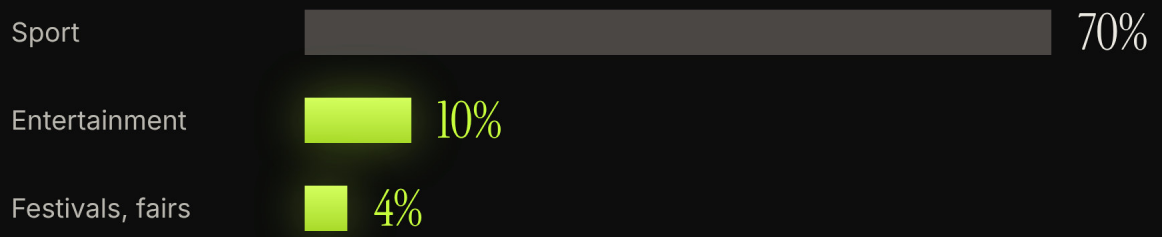
Goldman Sachs expects music revenue to grow 76% in ten years

Global music revenue, $bn



Sport takes seven times the sponsorship of entertainment

Share of North American sponsorship, 2018, the latest split published (total $24.2bn)



80%

call themselves fans of something, and 49% say ads work better when tailored to their fandom (Deloitte, 2026).

37% vs 24%

would buy from a brand partnering a musician they like, against other celebrities (Harris Poll, 2021, latest available).

$37.4bn

live music in 2025 (Goldman), and PwC says "live experiences function as social currency" (2026).

4.3

brand deals per top-200 artist, so there is room to grow (SponsorUnited, 2023-24).

Goldman Sachs, Music in the Air, via Hypebot 2026 · ESP Properties via Radio Ink 2018 · Deloitte 2026 · Harris Poll for Ad Age 2021 · PwC 2026 · SponsorUnited 2023-24

APPENDIX A4 · THE SQUEEZE

Streaming money is growing, but it reaches few artists.

Especially early in a career while fans take time to build, and AI makes up half of Deezer's new uploads.

PAY

Streaming passed $22bn in 2025, up 7.7% (IFPI, 2026). Spotify paid out over $11bn, yet only about 13,800 artists made $100,000 or more from it (Spotify, 2026), and 43% of UK musicians earn under £14,000 a year from music, with 53% needing other work (Musicians' Census, 2023).

AI

Over 50% of Deezer's new daily uploads were fully AI-made by June 2026, nearly 90,000 a day, although they win only 1 to 3% of streams and up to 85% of those plays were fraudulent in 2025 (Deezer, 2026).

INDEPENDENTS

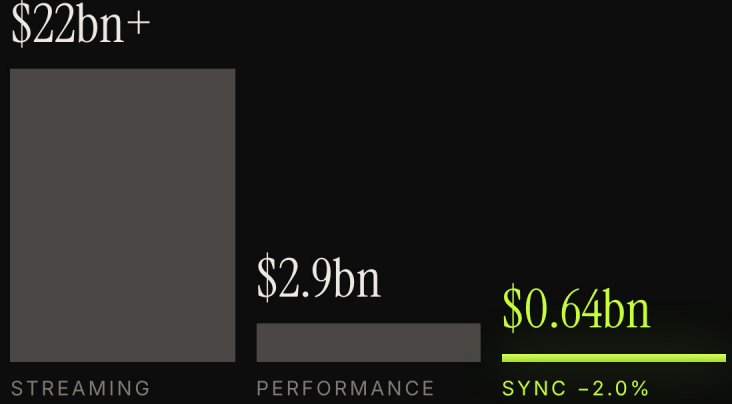
Roughly half of Spotify's royalties came from independent artists and labels (Spotify, 2026), yet a top-200 artist averages only 4.3 brand deals (SponsorUnited, 2023-24).

REAL FANS

A brand pays for an act playing to fans who turn up, and independent labels have many acts that do.

Sync is about 3% the size of streaming, and it shrank in 2025

Global recorded music revenue by source, 2025



THE GAP Artists need money that doesn't depend on stream counts, and brands have no measured route into independent rosters. I found no brand backing one over time.

IFPI Global Music Report 2026 · Spotify 2026 · Musicians' Census 2023 · Deezer 2026 · SponsorUnited 2023-24 · My sector search, Oct 2026

APPENDIX A5 · WHO'S DOING IT

Used thoughtfully, big brands can lift grassroots music and leave a lasting impact.

None of these brands has published what the partnership did for a label's roster.



RED BULL

A label of its own

Red Bull Music Academy backed about 60 new artists a year for 21 years (1998 to 2019). Red Bull Records (2007 to 2025) took AWOLNATION's "Sail" to diamond in the US.



DR. MARTENS

Tough as you

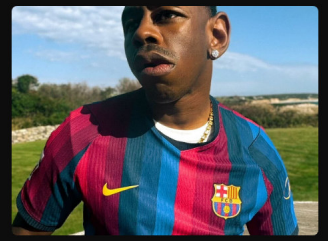
Intimate gigs in its Camden Boot Room with Shygirl and Arlo Parks (2019). It tracked brand confidence, awareness and younger wearers, and called sales "a by-product" (Amplify, 2020).



CUPRA

From festival to local scene

Main stage and a Boiler Room stage at Primavera Sound every year since 2022 (Cupra, 2024). In Manchester, its City Garage on St Ann Street gives local DJs free underground nights: 200+ events in its first year (Manchester's Finest, 2026).



SPOTIFY × BARÇA × GOLF

One shirt, three worlds

Spotify, Barça's shirt sponsor, handed its space to Tyler, The Creator's GOLF for El Clásico on 25 October. A Nike range followed (2026).

WHAT IT TELLS ME

The brands that win stay for years and put money into the scene itself. What is missing is someone working with the label who matches the brand to the act and measures what it did for the artist.

Red Bull Music Academy, Rolling Stone 2019 · Red Bull Records · Amplify 2020 · Cupra newsroom 2024 · Manchester's Finest 2026 · House of Heat 2026